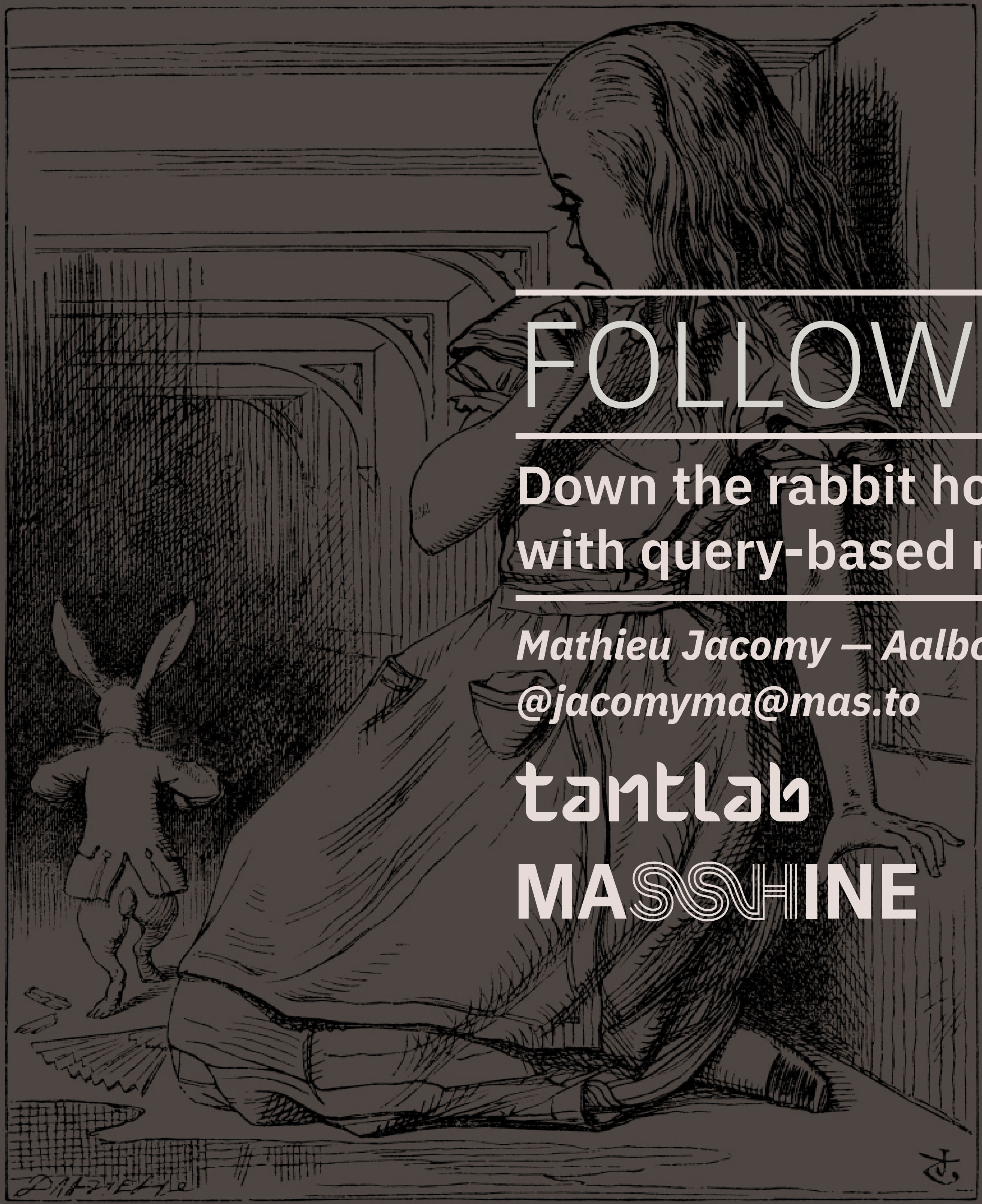


FOLLOW THE ACTORS

Down the rabbit hole(s) with query-based methods

Mathieu Jacomy — Aalborg University Tantlab + MASSHINE
@jacomyma@mas.to

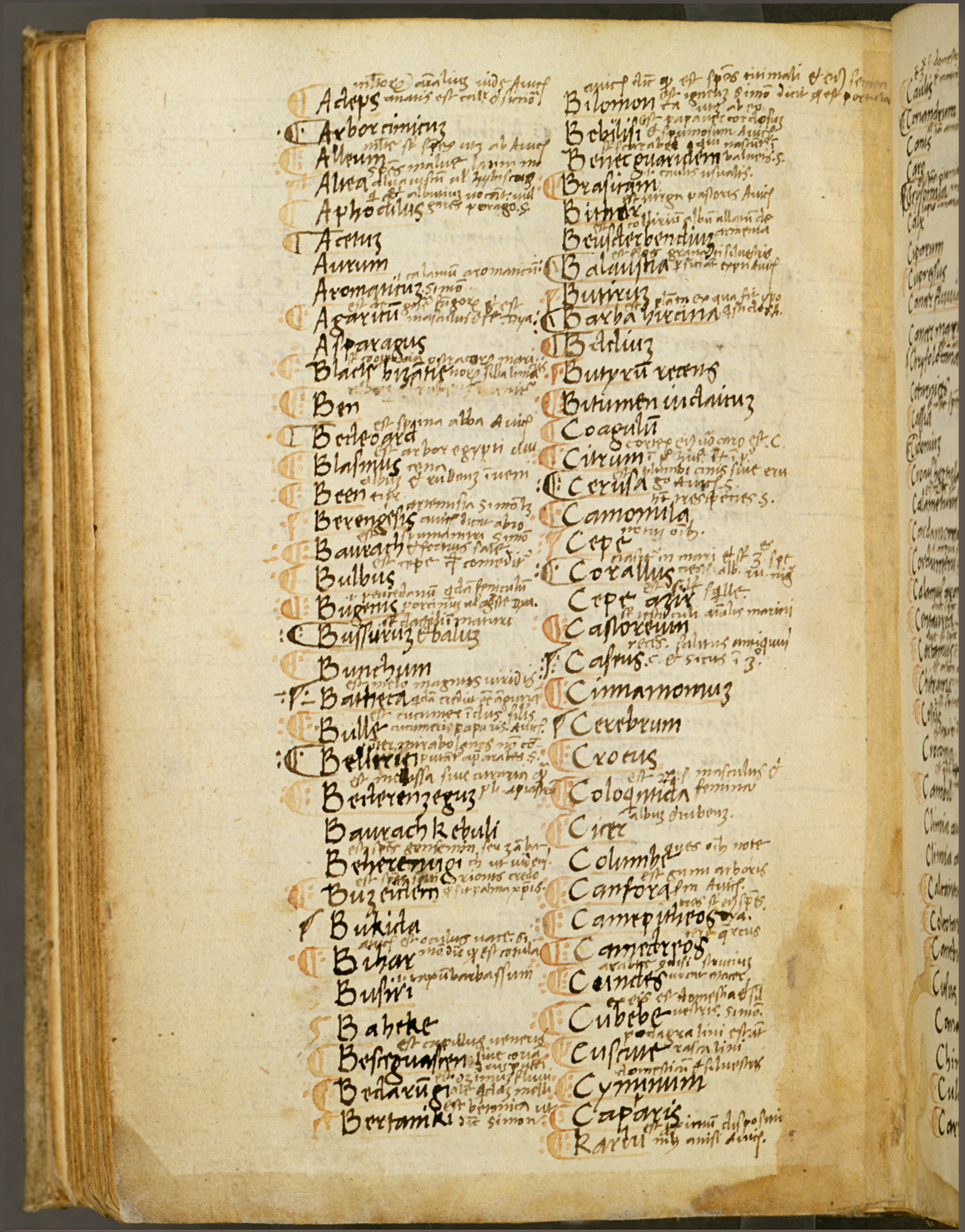
tantlab

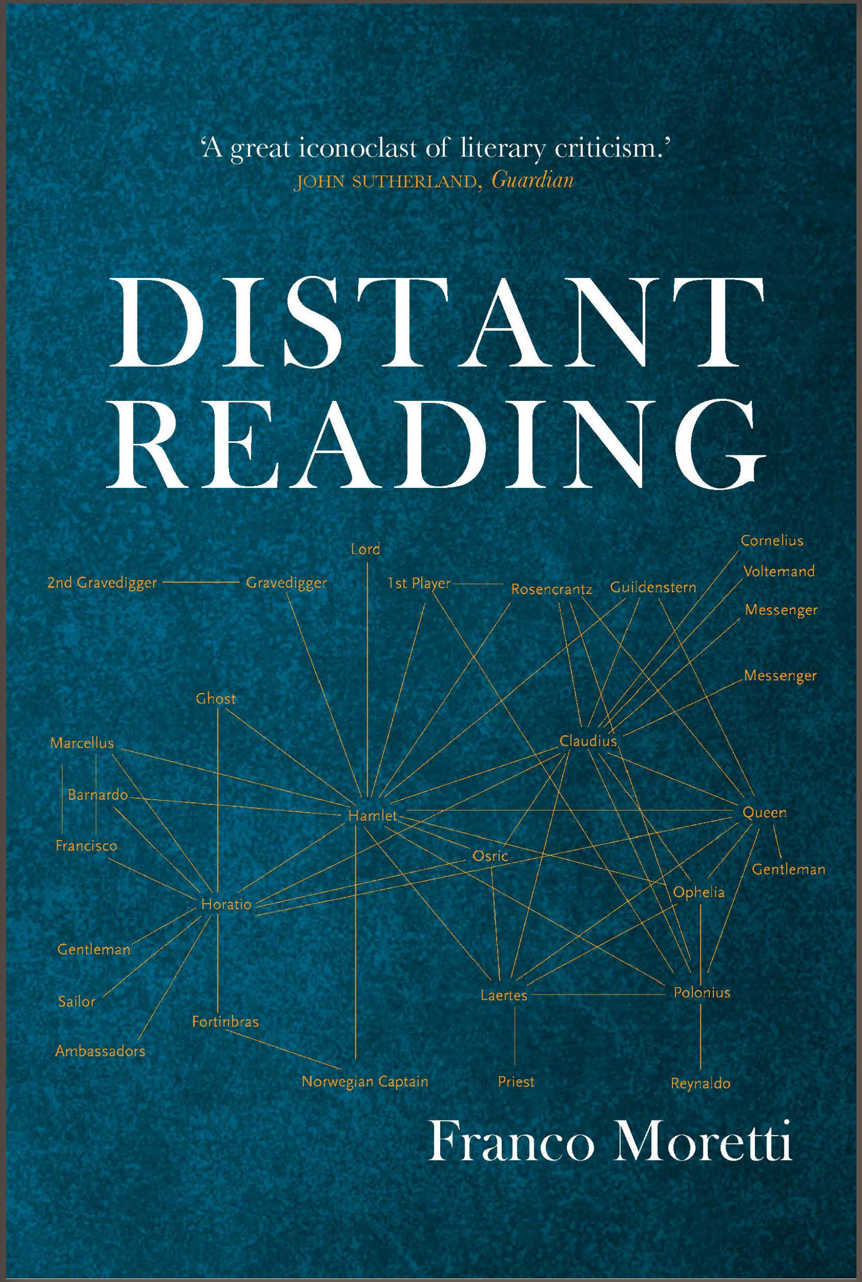
MASSHINE

Summary

1. Close and distant reading
2. Quali-quantitative analysis
3. Query-based methods
4. Principle of symmetry
5. What is an actor?
6. Follow the actors
7. Provide weighing

Close and distant reading





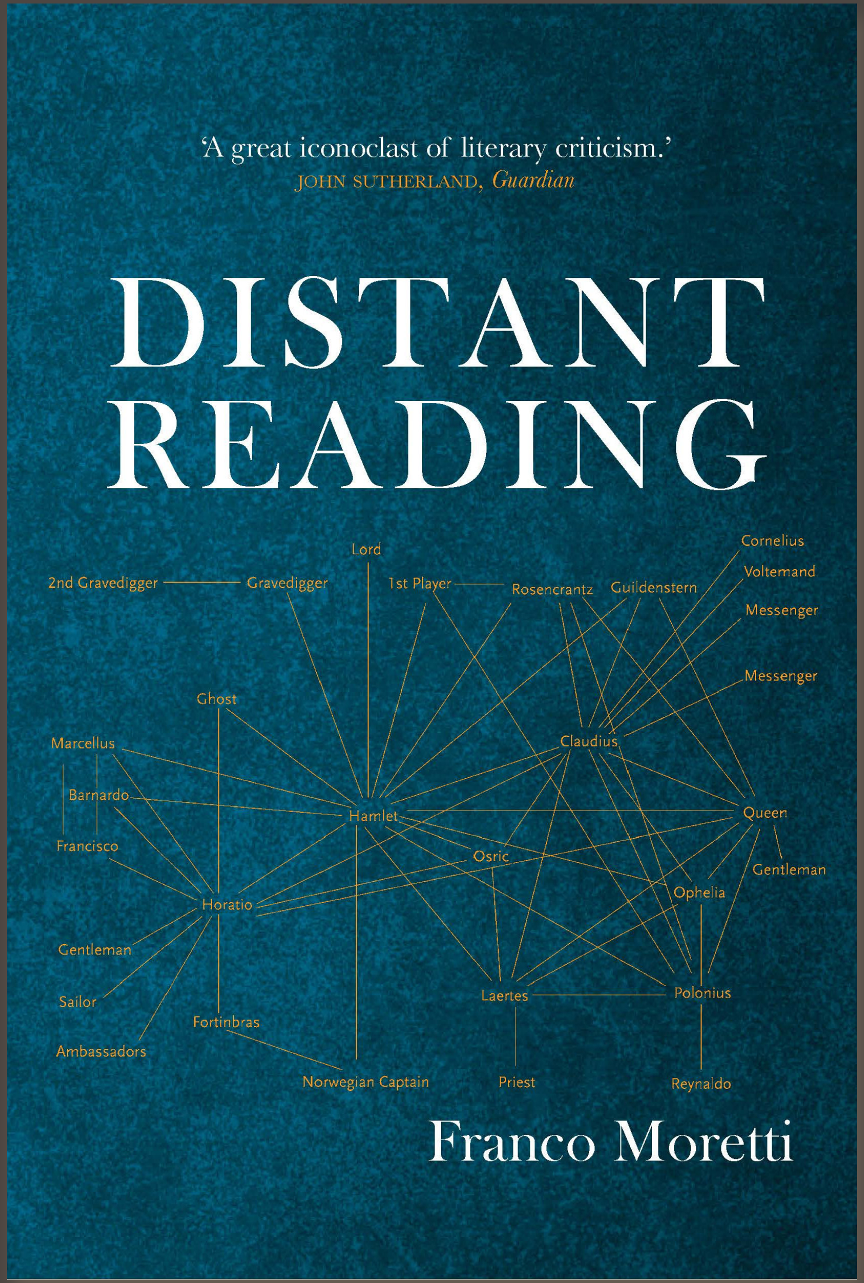
Close and distant reading

“[Distant reading is] a little pact with the devil: we know how to read texts, now let’s learn how not to read them.”

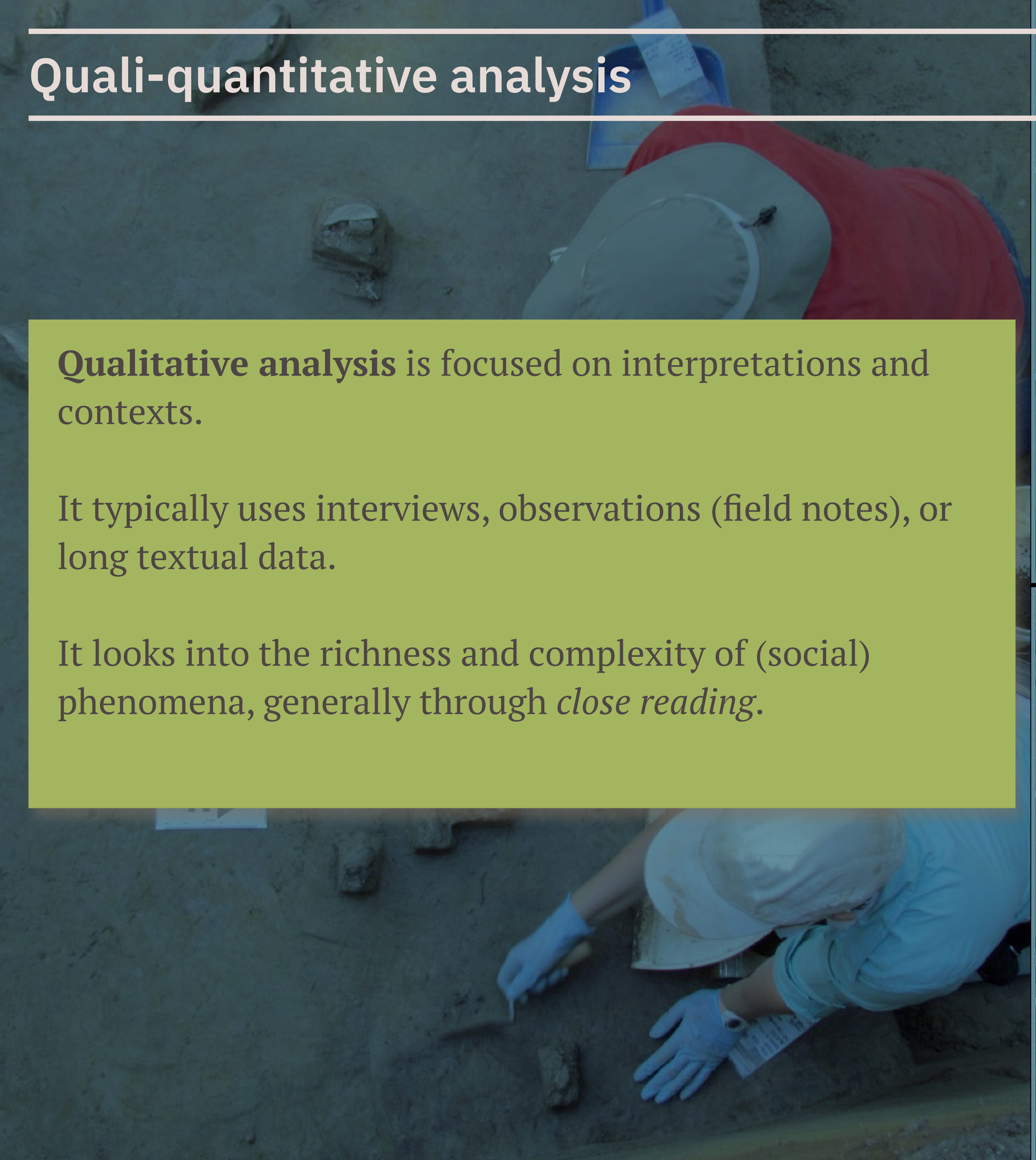
Moretti turns away from the traditional close reading by providing an abstract view of a literary text.

Breaking the structure to create new forms of overview.

Your exploration of the Energy Islands project de-facto qualifies as a ***distant reading*** of what is said about the project in the digital public space.



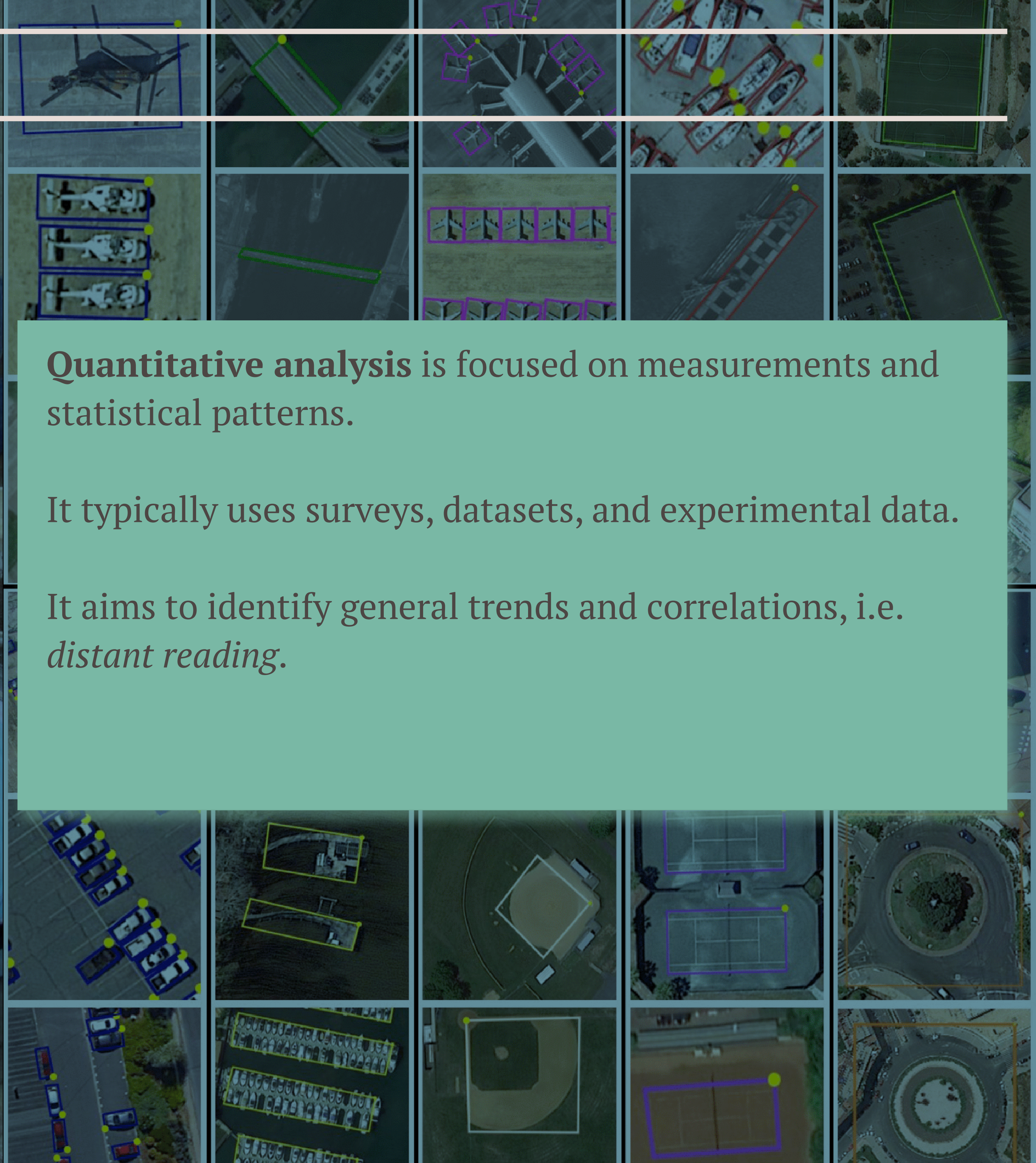
Quali-quantitative analysis



Qualitative analysis is focused on interpretations and contexts.

It typically uses interviews, observations (field notes), or long textual data.

It looks into the richness and complexity of (social) phenomena, generally through *close reading*.

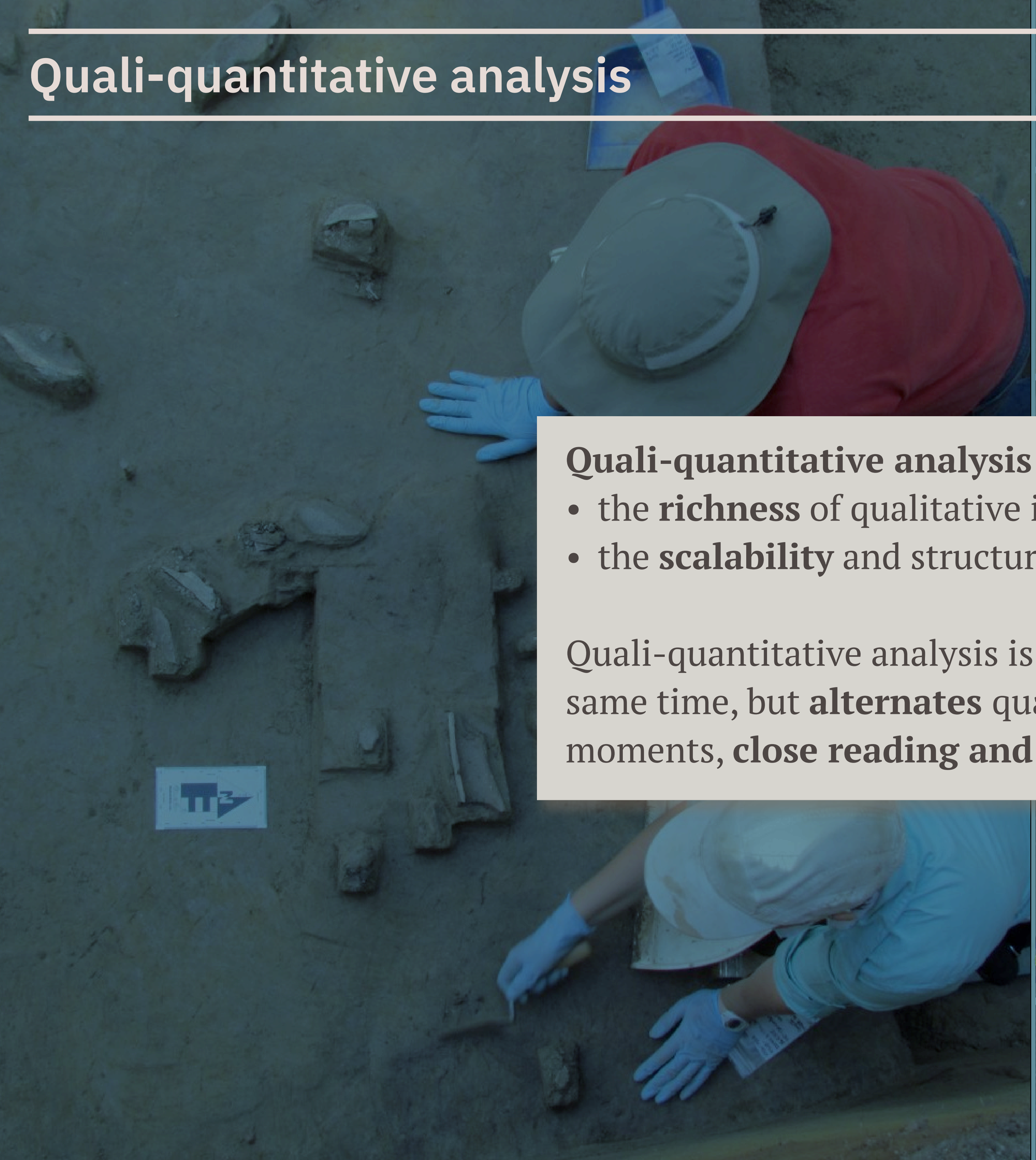


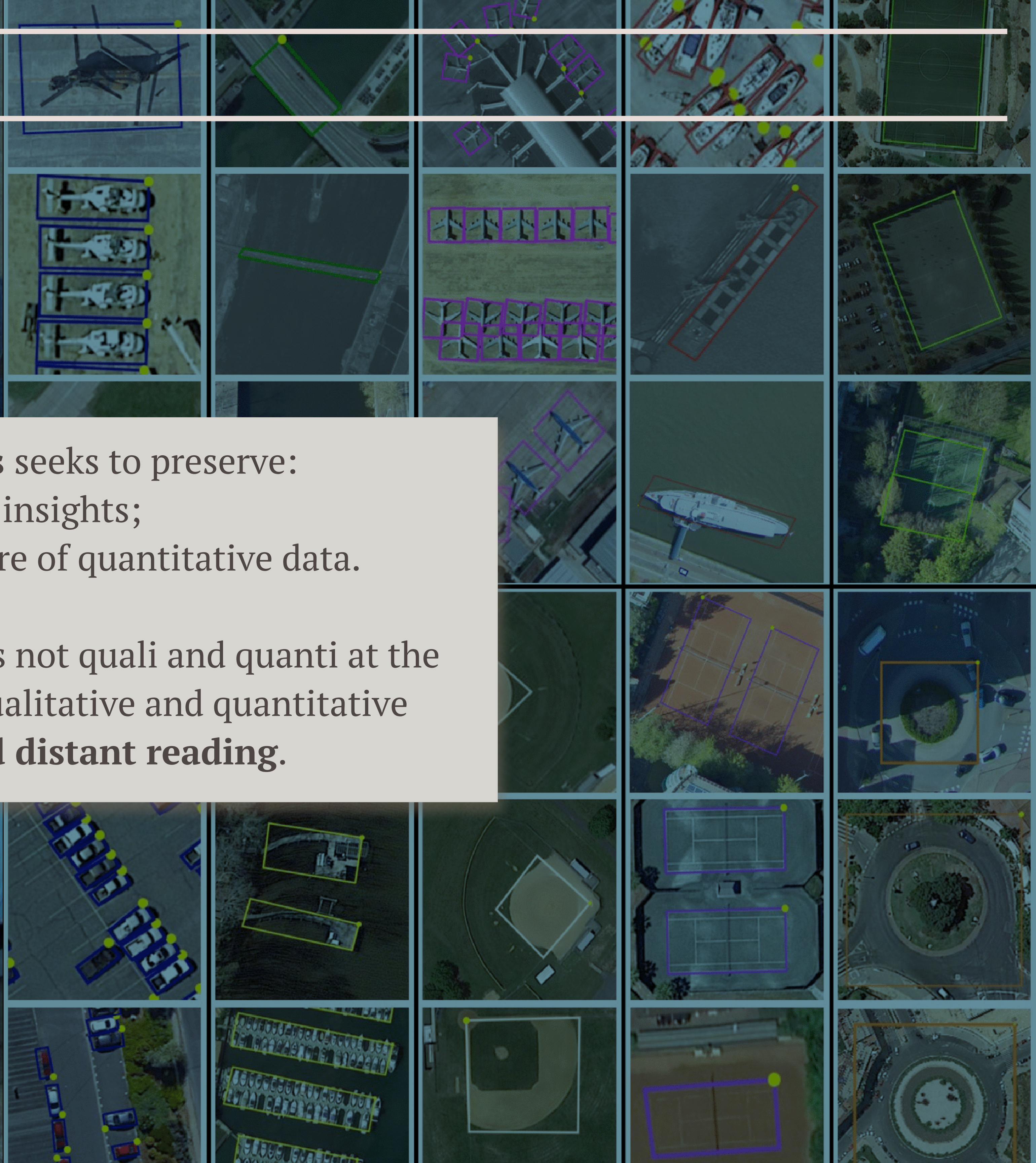
Quantitative analysis is focused on measurements and statistical patterns.

It typically uses surveys, datasets, and experimental data.

It aims to identify general trends and correlations, i.e. *distant reading*.

Quali-quantitative analysis





Quali-quantitative analysis seeks to preserve:

- the **richness** of qualitative insights;
- the **scalability** and structure of quantitative data.

Quali-quantitative analysis is not quali and quanti at the same time, but **alternates** qualitative and quantitative moments, **close reading and distant reading**.

Query-based methods

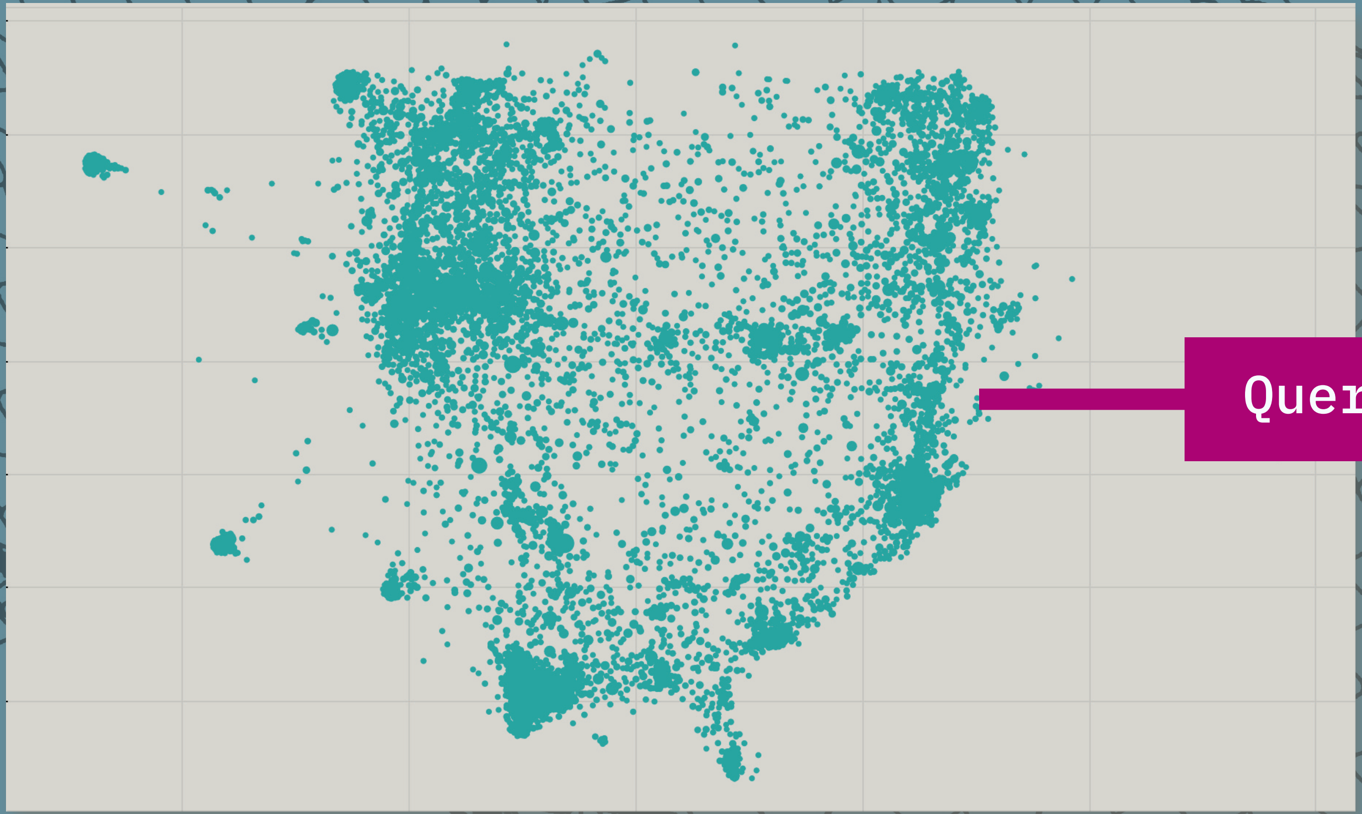
Think of a query as a **fishing net**:
A tool to capture the “fish” you need.

The strength of a *good* query resides in its ability to produce **meaningful** statistics.

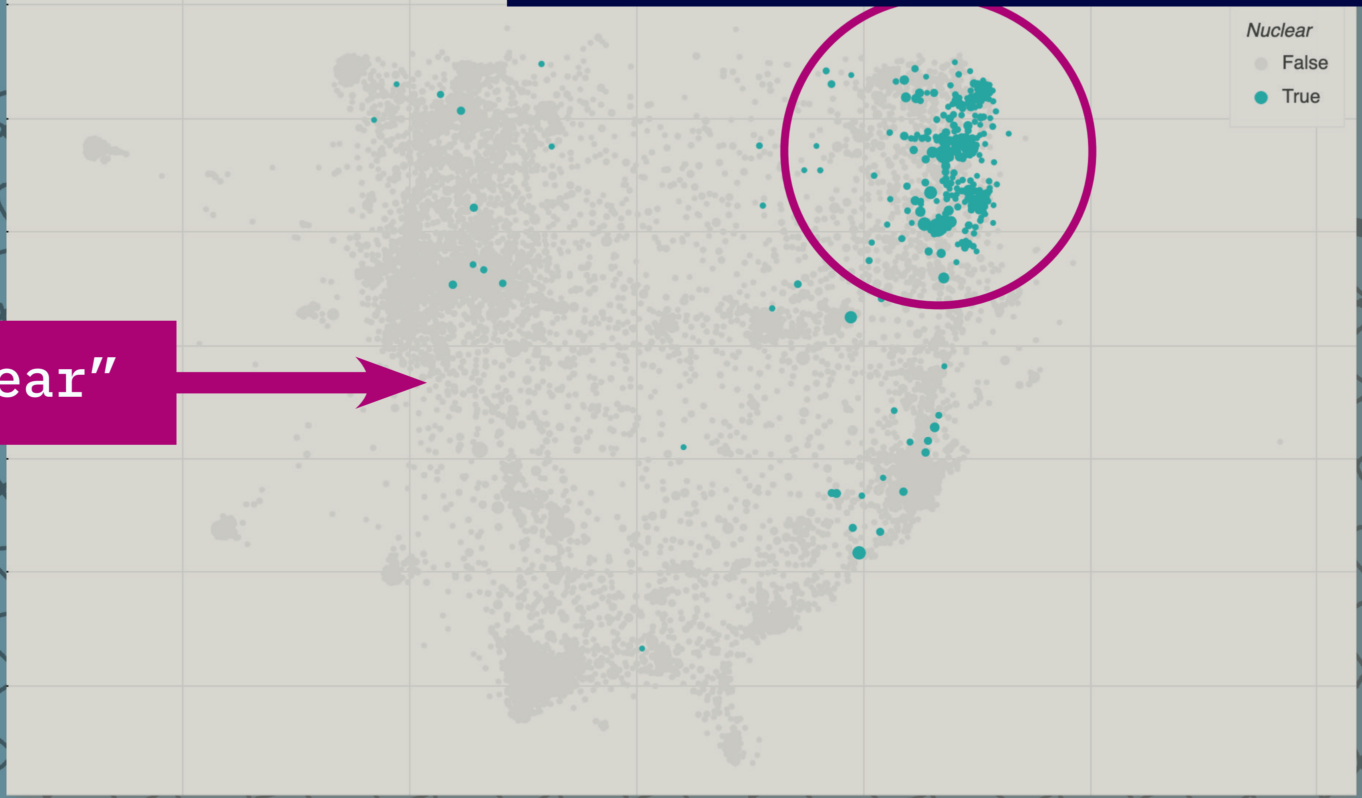
The “good” fishing net takes the necessary fish and *leaves the rest*.

Query-based methods

A good query is ***selective.***



Query: “nuclear”



Where to find (good) keywords

***Selective* expressions make good keywords:**

Proper nouns
ex: “Anthony Fauci”, “AstraZeneca”

Expert terms
ex: “B 1.1.7”, “Hydroxychloroquine”

Expressions with specific spelling
ex: “thicc”, “hodl”

Specific expressions
ex: “OK boomer”, “before the pandemic”

***Ambiguous* expressions make *bad* keywords.**

- Homonymy between persons
- Polysemy between expert terms

Where to find good keywords:

Experts provide useful keywords - but not all publics use the same words.
ex: “pandemic”, “B 1.1.7”, “china flu”

Even bad resources can provide good keywords: **read a lot**!

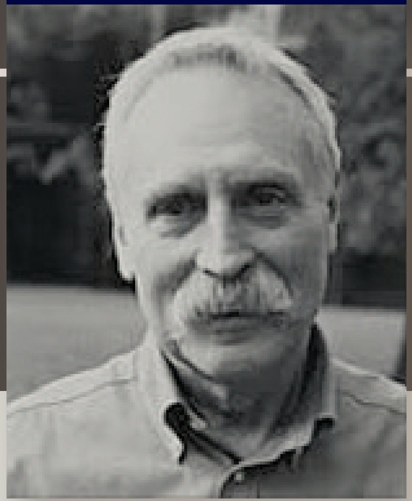
Marginal resources provide alternative keywords, which is necessary. Step out of your sphere / comfort zone.

The process is iterative.

Query design is not primarily about the technicity of compositing, but about the selective effect of good keywords.

Principle of symmetry

David Bloor



The principle of symmetry roots in David Bloor's "strong programme" for the sociology of scientific knowledge.

Characteristics [edit]

As formulated by David Bloor,[3] the strong programme has four indispensable components:

1. *Causality*: it examines the conditions (psychological, social, and cultural) that bring about claims to a certain kind of knowledge.
2. *Impartiality*: it examines successful as well as unsuccessful knowledge claims.
3. *Symmetry*: the same types of explanations are used for successful and unsuccessful knowledge claims alike.
4. *Reflexivity*: it must be applicable to sociology itself.

rests. Sociology would be only marginally relevant to successful theories, which succeeded because they had reveal

e. The strong programme proposed that both "true" and "false" scientific theories should be treated the same way. Bo

social factors or conditions, such as cultural context and self-interest. All human knowledge, as something that exist

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Strong_programme

We must be able to understand the knowledge claims of flat earthers as well as the knowledge claims of renowned physicists.

What is an actor?

An actor is someone or something that makes a difference to the situation.

Key takeaway:

We are mainly interested in actors insofar as we can track and document which difference(s) they make to the Energy Island project and the discourses about it.

For us, an actor is an actor because it makes knowledge claims that influence decisions, answer open questions, shape the public debate, mobilize new actors, or make a difference in any other way.

Follow the actors

Principle of symmetry:
We do not investigate according to our own beliefs, because it does not allow us to describe the actors we disagree with.

We follow the actors to some uncomfortable places we disapprove.

In practice:
- We “listen” to actors (close reading).
- We pay attention to the terms and arguments they use
- We do not replace their specific words with ours (we quote).
- We **leverage their words as markers for query methods**.

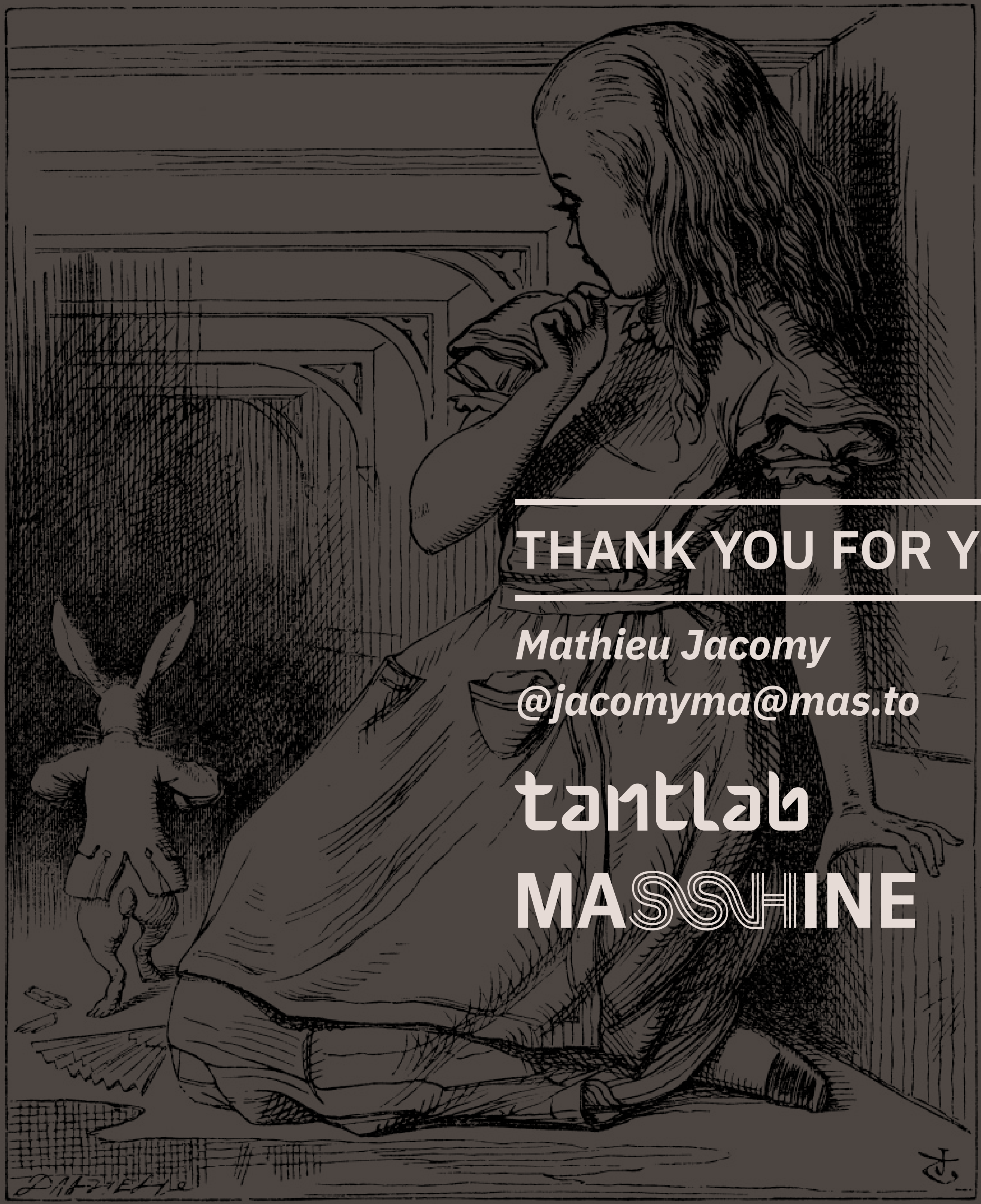
Weigh positions

Some actors make a bigger difference than others.
(they are "stronger") **You must show it.**

Provide a description (a measurement) of each actor's **ability to make a difference** to the Energy Islands project and the discussions about it (second-degree objectivity).

Examples:

- their knowledge claims were repeated by more other actors;
- they convinced more policy makers to take action;
- theywere more influential on what topics are debated on social media;
- etc.



THANK YOU FOR YOUR ATTENTION

Mathieu Jacomy
@jacomyma@mas.to

tantlab

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